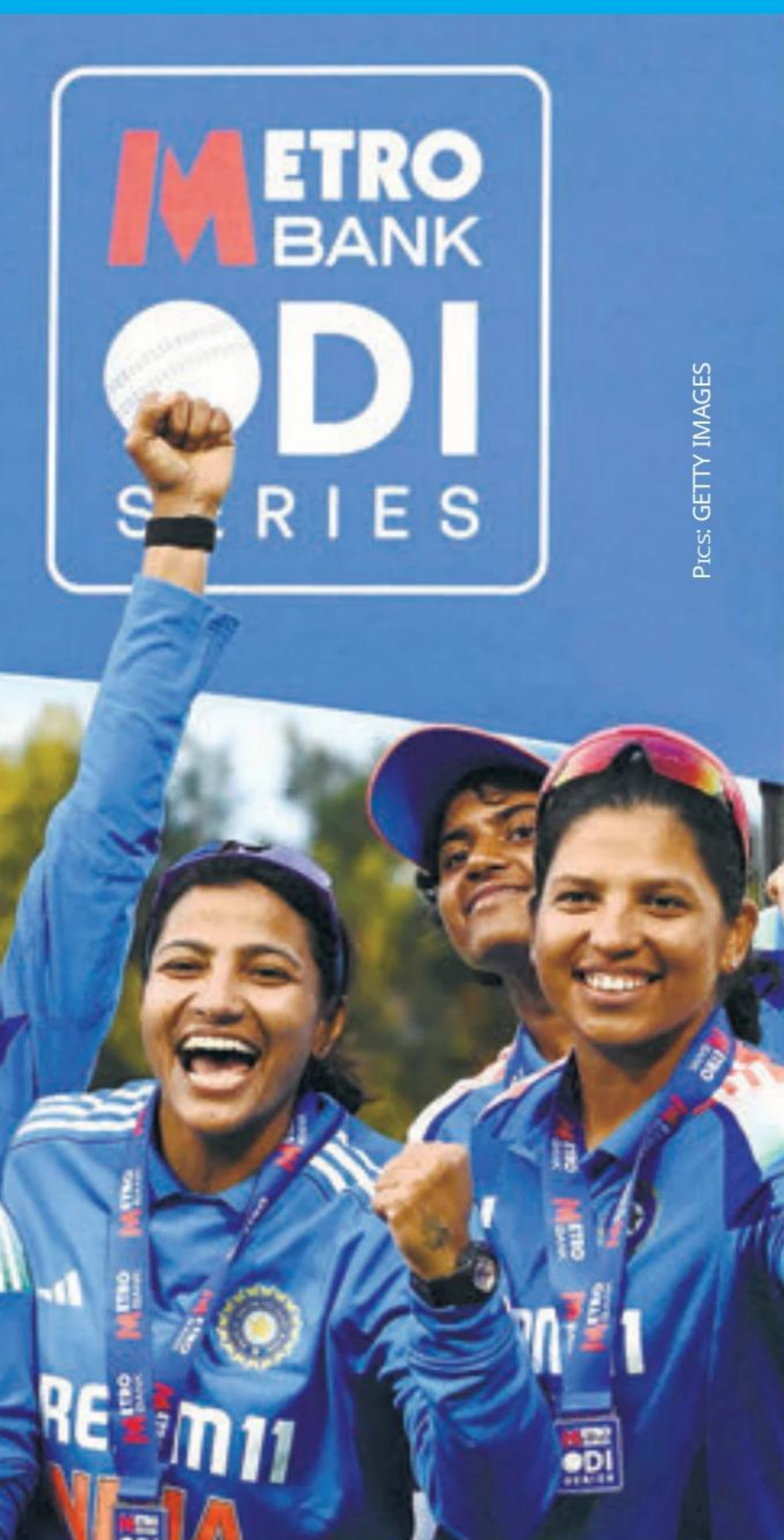




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A stuttering New Zealand put on quite the all-round show in the second of three ODIs in November 2024, with Sophie Devine leading the way with a half-century and three wickets. The Kiwis may have tamely surrendered the series to India in the next fixture, but that loss left India with an itch. Old ailments returned to haunt the side: a limp top order, poor fielding, and a bowling attack that crumbled under pressure.

India then headed to Australia, only to have its vulnerabilities laid bare. A merciless 0-3 hammering followed, including a performance that saw India bowled out for just 100 (in the first ODI). India's batting — barring a century from Smriti Mandhana and a fifty from Richa Ghosh in different games — largely failed.

While Saima Thakor and Arundhati Reddy — who stunned all with a career-best spell (four for 26



in the third ODI) — showed promise, it wasn't enough to stop a wounded Australian machine, fresh from the heartbreak of a T20 World Cup semifinal exit.

As unfashionable as it is to state, India's runs against West Indies — lone wolf Hayley Matthews' valiant resistance notwithstanding — and Ireland were expected to be comfortable. The Women in Blue utilised those two series to embark on a milestone-collecting spree, achieving record totals and massive wins.

They also laid the foundation for a promising new top-order pairing of Smriti and Pratika Rawal. Harleen Deol, with a century under her belt, made a case to claim the No.3 spot. Sneha Rana made a comeback to the ODI setup after 485 days and marked her return with a match-winning fiver against South Africa. Scribbled in the corner of every series review, though, was the question about a restless Shafali Verma warming the bench after being shunted out of the ODI setup for inconsistency since India's tour of Australia.

Sri Lanka challenged India in the tri-series, handing it its only loss of the tournament in the league stage.

Solid at the top: Smriti Mandhana's command early in the innings has helped India set up some big scores this year.



Mercurial: Shafali Verma's briskness, aggressive strokeplay, and blatant disregard for reputation are inimitable.